Howes at the British Library; Dr Shailendra Bhandhare at the Ashmolean Museum; Professor John Coningham at the University of Durham. Also Harry Marshall, Douglas Rice, J. M. Kenoyer and R. H. Meadow. In Germany: Professor Harry Falk, Dr Monika Zin and Dr Julia Hegevald.

In India: Nirmala Lakshman, Mahima Jain and their colleagues at *The Hindu* newspaper group in Chennai; Dr Naman Ahuja, John Elliott, Shantum Seth, Parvati Menon, V. K. Ramachandran and Madhura Swaminathan, Timeri Murari, Dhananjay Chavan and Shyam Syamaprasad. Also that polymath and most generous of hosts Aman Nath, who so kindly offered us the hospitality of the palaces, forts, mansions and homes along the Coromandel and Malabar coasts which he and the late Francis Wacziarg so lovingly restored to become part of his Neemrana 'non-hotels' group – specifically, Hotel de l'Orient at Pondicherry, the 'Bungalow on the Beach' at Tranquebar, and Le Colonial and the Tower House at Cochin.

Iain Hunt at Little, Brown very kindly read my first draft and made many useful suggestions before my manuscript was delivered to his successor as editor, Nithya Rae, whose own background experience and professional skills proved invaluable. Thank you, too, to Linda Silverman for securing permissions for the illustrations, and to John Gilkes for his superb maps. My gratitude, also, to Tim Whiting, commissioning editor at Little, Brown, whose faith in me has been sorely tried over the years but whose unwavering support has sustained my belief that there is still a place for history writing in modern publishing. These same sentiments can equally be applied to Vivien Green, who has stood by me through storm and sunshine for all these years as literary agent and friend.

My last word of thanks goes to my fellow travellers, for their usual forbearance and their company: Richard Davies from time to time and my beloved wife Liz.